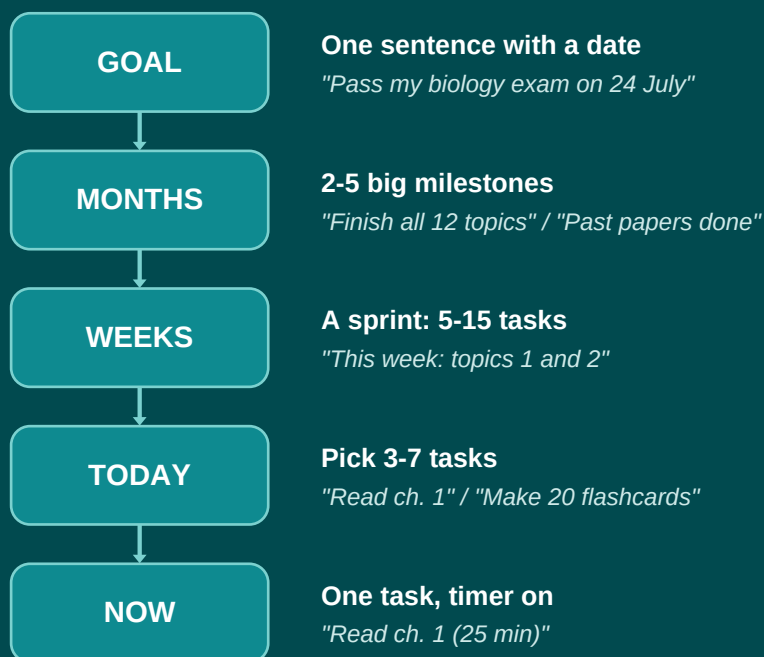


From “I have no idea” to a plan you can do today

The Beginner's Guide to DevPlanner — how to take any goal (an exam, a project, your whole messy week) and break it into months, weeks, and days. No experience needed.

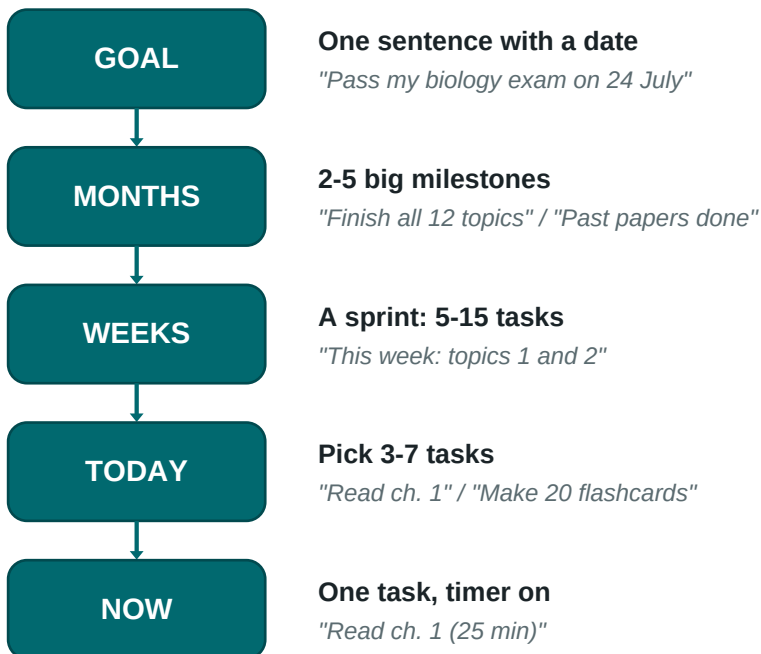


Inside: the one idea behind all planning • a 4-question recipe for making goals • what to do when you have no syllabus or structure • worked examples for daily life, exams, and work • a 10-minute first run • a one-page cheat sheet.

1. The one idea behind all planning

Here is the secret nobody tells you: **you can't “do” a goal.** Nobody has ever sat down and “done” *pass the exam* or *launch the app*. The only thing a human can actually do is a small task: read one chapter, write one email, fix one bug. Goals are only reachable when they've been broken into tasks small enough to do today.

So planning is just one move, repeated: **break the big thing into smaller things until the smallest thing fits in your day.** We call this the ladder:



The only rule that matters

Every level answers one question. Goal: *where am I going?* Months: *what are the big chunks?* Weeks: *which chunk is this week's job?* Today: *which 3-7 tasks today?* Now: *which ONE thing right now?* If you're ever lost, find the question you can't answer — that's the level you need to fix.

DevPlanner is built around this ladder. Each part of the app is one rung, which is why it never feels like “where do I put this?” once you know the map on the next page.

2. The app in plain words

DevPlanner has four pages plus an AI helper. Each one answers exactly one question:

Place	The question it answers	What you do there
Today	"What am I doing right now?"	See today's 3-7 tasks, start a timer on one, tick things off. This is where you live during the day.
Inbox	"Where do I throw new stuff?"	Every idea, chore, and worry lands here first — unsorted, zero pressure. Empty your head into it.
Plan	"What happens this week / month?"	Arrange the future: weekly sprints, a board, a timeline, a table, and your long-term Goals grid.
Review	"How did it go?"	Once a week: count your wins, carry over the rest, set next week's top 3. Takes 15 minutes.
AI helper	"Can someone do this thinking for me?"	The round button, bottom right. It sorts your brain dumps, breaks tasks into steps, and — if you allow it — creates and organizes tasks for you.

The five words the app uses

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Area	A bucket of your life	Work, Personal, Professional (school fits here too)
Task	One thing to do, starts with a verb	"Revise chapter 3"
Subtask	A bite of a task (the real unit you do)	"Make 20 flashcards for ch. 3"
Sprint	One week's basket of tasks	"Week of 15 June"
Recurring	A task that comes back by itself	"Review flashcards — every day"

Don't memorize this

You only need two habits to start: **throw everything into Inbox** (press Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+D anywhere) and **pick 3-7 things each morning on Today**. Everything else in this guide makes those two habits stronger.

3. How to make a goal (when your head is empty)

“Set a goal” is useless advice if nobody shows you how. Here is the recipe. Answer four questions, in order, writing one line each:

1. **What do I want to be TRUE, by WHEN?** One sentence, with a date: “By 24 July, I have passed the biology exam.” “By 1 September, my portfolio site is online.” If there's no date, pick one — a guessed date beats no date.
2. **How will I know it happened?** Name the proof: a grade, a link that works, money in the account. If you can't name proof, the goal is still a wish — sharpen it.
3. **What are the 2-5 big chunks between me and that?** Don't aim for perfect — aim for “roughly, what has to exist?” For an exam: know the topics, practice questions, memorize key facts. For a website: content written, design done, site published.
4. **What is the first 25-minute task?** Something so small you could do it tonight: “find the syllabus PDF”, “list the textbook chapters”, “register the domain”.

Stuck on question 3? Never invent structure — borrow it.

This is the move that unlocks everything when you have **no reading guideline, no syllabus, no clue**: someone has already broken your goal into parts. Steal their list.

- **Exam?** Use the syllabus topics. No syllabus? Use the textbook's table of contents. No textbook? Collect past exam questions and group them by topic — the groups ARE your topics.
- **Skill?** Copy the chapter list of any popular course or book on it.
- **Work project?** List the parts the finished thing must contain (a report = sections; an app = screens).
- **Still stuck?** Open the AI helper and type: “*Break [my goal] into 4-6 big chunks.*” Then delete what doesn't fit. Editing a wrong list is 10× easier than writing on a blank page.

Then spread it over the calendar (the easy math)

- Count what you have: **12 topics**, and count the time: **6 weeks**.
- Divide: $12 \div 6 = 2$ **topics per week**. That's your weekly sprint, decided by arithmetic, not anxiety.
- Keep the **last 10-20% of the time for nothing new** — only practice, polish, and fixing weak spots.
- Each week, on Sunday, pull that week's chunk into tasks. Each morning, pick 3-7 of them for Today.

That's the entire method. Goal in one sentence, chunks borrowed from someone else's structure, division to get the weekly load, and 3-7 tasks a day. The rest of this guide is just this recipe applied to real situations.

4. Your first 10 minutes in DevPlanner

Do this once, right after signing in. The app shows a “Get set up in 2 minutes” checklist on Today that walks you through the same steps.

1. **Empty your head (3 min).** Press **Ctrl/Cmd + Shift + D** (or the checklist's “Brain Dump” button). Type everything you're carrying — one item per line, tasks and worries alike. There's a microphone button if you'd rather talk. Don't sort, don't judge, just dump.
2. **Let the AI sort it (1 min).** Click **“Parse with AI”**. Each line becomes a draft task with a guessed priority, effort, and bucket (today / this week / backlog). Fix anything it got wrong, then save. Everything lands in your **Inbox**.
3. **Pick today's 3 (2 min).** Go to **Today**. Use “Pull from Inbox” to bring in at most **one big, three medium, five small** tasks. When in doubt, pick fewer — finishing 3 beats starting 8.
4. **Do one (now).** The top task shows in the Work block. Press **Start**. Work until you finish or stop; press **Done**. Enjoy the confetti — you've earned it.
5. **Optional: connect your calendar (2 min).** Settings → Calendar → Connect Google Calendar. Scheduled tasks then appear on your normal calendar automatically.

The 1-3-5 day shape

A day that actually finishes looks like this — not like a 20-item wishlist:

1 big thing — 60-120 min, needs focus

up to 3 medium — about 30 min each

up to 5 small — 5-15 min: emails, calls, chores

DevPlanner shows this mix on Today (“1 big / 3 medium / 5 small” counters) and tracks a daily capacity in minutes. It learns from what you really complete: if you keep finishing about 3 hours of work a day, it stops pretending you'll do 6, and plans around 3. Overflow rolls to tomorrow with your approval (“Preview rollover”) — nothing moves behind your back.

5. Scenario: plain daily planning

No big goal — just life: chores, errands, work bits, and the constant feeling of forgetting something.

The daily rhythm (10 minutes total)

When	What	Where
All day	Anything pops into your head? Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+D, type it, close. 5 seconds.	Inbox
Morning (5 min)	Open Today. Pull 1 big + up to 3 medium + up to 5 small from Inbox. Check the capacity bar isn't red.	Today
During work	Press Start on one task. Finish it or stop the timer. Press Done. Repeat.	Today
Evening (2 min)	Didn't finish something? Click "Preview rollover" and approve — it moves to tomorrow without guilt.	Today
Sunday (15 min)	Review: wins, carryover, next week's top 3. The app turns it into next week's sprint.	Review

Match tasks to your energy, not the clock

Every task can be marked **deep work** (needs full brain), **shallow**, **admin** (forms, emails), or **quick win**. Today has an energy filter: feeling sharp → show deep work; feeling flat → show admin and quick wins. Tired days still count if the right tasks get done.

Make boring stuff recurring

Bills, laundry, watering plants, weekly reports: set a repeat rule on the task (for example *every Monday*). When you tick it off, DevPlanner automatically creates the next one on the next date. You will never re-remember a chore again.

If you only adopt one habit

Capture everything into Inbox the moment you think of it. A thought written down stops nagging you. Your head is for having ideas, not for storing them.

6. Scenario: an exam, with no reading guideline

The scariest version of studying: a date on the calendar, a pile of material, and nobody telling you what to read when. Let's walk the recipe with a real example — **biology exam, 6 weeks away**.

1. **Goal sentence:** “By 24 July, I pass biology with 70%+.” Proof: the grade.
2. **Borrow the structure:** no reading guideline, so open the textbook's table of contents — say it lists **12 chapters**. That list IS the plan. (No textbook? Group 3 years of past questions by theme; the themes are your chapters. Or ask the AI helper to list the standard topics for your exam.)
3. **Do the math:** 6 weeks × with the last week reserved for past papers = 5 study weeks. 12 chapters ÷ 5 ≈ **2-3 chapters per week**. The math just wrote your study plan:

Week (sprint)	Job	Day-by-day looks like
Week 1	Chapters 1-3	Mon: read ch.1 + flashcards • Tue: 10 questions ch.1 • Wed: read ch.2 + cards • ...
Week 2	Chapters 4-6	Same pattern. Plus 15 min/day: review old flashcards (recurring task).
Week 3	Chapters 7-9	Same pattern. Friday: redo every question you got wrong so far.
Week 4	Chapters 10-12	Same pattern.
Week 5	Weak spots only	Re-read worst 3 chapters; re-do their questions until clean.
Week 6	Past papers	One timed paper every 2 days; mark it; fix what failed. Nothing new.

How to enter it in DevPlanner (15 minutes, once)

1. Plan → Sprints → create “Exam week 1” ... “Exam week 6” with their dates. (Or finish a weekly Review — it creates next week's sprint for you.)
2. For each chapter, create one task: “Learn chapter 4”, and put it in its week's sprint.
3. Open a task → ask the AI to **break it down** → you get subtasks like “read + summarize”, “make 20 flashcards”, “do 10 questions”. Use “**Spread subtasks across days**” to lay them over the week.
4. Create one recurring task: “Review flashcards — 15 min”, repeating every day. Tick it daily; it respawns itself.
5. Each morning: open Today, pull the day's study subtasks, press Start on the first one.

Why this beats “study harder”

On any given morning you never decide “what should I study?” — the plan already decided. Your only job is the next 25-minute block. Decisions are what drain you; the ladder removes them.

7. Scenario: work — a project with a deadline

A report, a feature, a launch, a client deliverable — anything with a “due by”. Work goals are the easiest to break down because the finished thing has visible parts.

1. **Goal sentence:** “By 31 July, the quarterly report is sent to the director.”
2. **Walk backwards from the deadline:** sent on the 31st ← reviewed by a colleague around the 28th ← full draft by the 21st ← data collected by the 14th ← outline by the 7th. Those dates are your month-level milestones — put each one in as a task with a due date.
3. **Each week's sprint = the milestone of that week**, broken into tasks that start with verbs: “pull sales numbers”, “draft section 2”, “make the 3 charts”, “ask Dapo to review”.
4. **Define “done” for every task.** “Work on report” is a trap — you can “work on” forever. “Draft section 2 (rough is fine)” can actually finish.
5. **Protect one deep-work block a day.** Mark the writing/building tasks as deep work, schedule them for your sharpest hours (DevPlanner learns your peak hours from your timers and suggests them), and batch the emails into one admin block.

The two-list trick for meetings-heavy jobs

Keep project tasks and “reactive” tasks (emails, pings, requests) separate. Reactive stuff goes to Inbox all day and gets a single afternoon admin block. Your 1 big thing each day should almost always be a project task — otherwise the urgent eats the important, every day, forever.

8. Every other scenario — same ladder

You want to...	Borrow structure from	Week looks like
Get fit	Any beginner program (e.g. couch-to-5k): its weeks are your sprints	3 recurring workout tasks + 1 meal-prep task
Learn to code	A course's module list	2 modules + 1 tiny build project per week
Save money	Your bank statement's categories	1 weekly “review spending” recurring task + one cut per week
Write a book	Chapter outline (even a bad one)	A daily recurring “write 300 words” + Friday “revise”
Job hunt	Stages: list → CV → apply → interview prep	“Apply to 5” + “prep one interview answer” daily

For life-sized direction, open **Plan** → **Goals**: a simple grid of short / mid / long term × personal / professional / work. One sentence per box is enough — it's the compass your weekly sprints should roughly point at. Review it monthly, not daily.

9. The weekly rhythm (15 minutes that hold it together)

Plans rot in about a week. The fix is a tiny weekly reset — DevPlanner's **Review** tab walks you through it step by step:

1. **Wins** — list what got done. (The page shows your time per area vs. your weekly targets.)
2. **Carryover** — what didn't finish, and what actually blocked it.
3. **Top 3 intentions** — the three things that matter most next week.
4. **Draft sprint** — rough notes on what goes in next week's basket.
5. **Finish** — the app creates next week's sprint automatically. Add the tasks, done.

Want effort targets? Settings → Areas lets you set weekly hour targets per area (say, 10h study, 3h fitness). Timers feed the Review page's progress bars, so you can see where the week really went.

10. When it goes wrong (it will — that's normal)

What happened	What to do (the app helps)
I missed two days completely	Don't double tomorrow. Open Today → "Preview rollover", approve the moves, and continue as if the plan always said this. A plan you restart instantly is worth more than a perfect one.
My list is always too long	That's not a character flaw — your capacity number is just smaller than your hopes. DevPlanner learns your real pace and plans to it. Cooperate: fewer, smaller tasks. Finishing builds momentum; overplanning kills it.
I keep avoiding one task	It's too big or too vague. Rewrite it to start with a verb and fit in 45 minutes, or open it and let the AI break it into subtasks. Then do only the first subtask.
I have zero motivation today	Set the energy filter to Low, do two quick wins, start a 10-minute timer on anything. Motivation usually follows starting — not the other way round.
I deleted something by mistake	Every delete shows an Undo button for a few seconds. Click it. Crisis over.

The one-page cheat sheet

Print this page. It's the whole system.

The 7 rules

- **1.** Goals are sentences with dates. Tasks are verbs that fit in a day. Never confuse the two.
- **2.** Never invent structure — borrow it (syllabus, table of contents, past papers, course outline, or ask the AI).
- **3.** Divide chunks by weeks left. The arithmetic is the plan. Reserve the last 10-20% for practice/polish.
- **4.** A day is 1 big + up to 3 medium + up to 5 small. When in doubt, plan less.
- **5.** Everything new goes to Inbox first (Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+D). Sort later, capture now.
- **6.** Unfinished work rolls forward guilt-free — approve the rollover and keep moving.
- **7.** Fifteen minutes of Review every week. This is the rule that keeps the other six alive.

Shortcuts & buttons

Where	Action	What it does
Anywhere	Ctrl/Cmd + Shift + D	Brain Dump — capture thoughts (type or speak)
Anywhere	Ctrl/Cmd + K	Search / command menu
Anywhere	Alt + T	Notifications tray
Anywhere	AI button (bottom right)	Ask for plans, breakdowns, progress; tick “Can edit” to let it create/organize tasks
Today	Start / Done	Timer on the current task; Done ticks it off (recurring tasks respawn)
Today	Preview rollover	Approve moving unfinished work forward
Plan → Goals	—	Short/mid/long-term goals grid (your compass)
Settings → Areas	—	Weekly hour targets per life area
Settings → Calendar	—	Google Calendar / CalDAV two-way sync

The 4-question goal recipe

1. What do I want to be true, by when? (one sentence + date)
2. How will I know? (the proof)
3. What are the 2-5 big chunks? (borrow the structure!)
4. What's the first 25-minute task? (do it today)

That's everything. You don't need discipline made of steel or a perfect system — you need a ladder, an inbox, 3-7 honest tasks a day, and a 15-minute Sunday. DevPlanner holds the structure; you just climb one rung at a time.